

Ku Ku the bird:
A story of resilience



With the warmth of the morning sun on their feathers, Ku Ku's family looked up, spread their wings, and soared high into the sky to join their bird community.

Ku Ku loved to fly, and sang out in joy as the breeze blew under and along the feathers on their wings. Higher and higher the bird community flew, their wings flapping goodbye to their old nests in the mountains as they started the long journey towards their new nests in the hills.

Ku Ku was from a community of birds that had to migrate when the weather changed and became too cold. They didn't have the big warm feathers that they needed in colder places.

"Brrrrrr" Ku Ku shivered as they felt their feathers stand on end. Partially because Ku Ku was cold and also because Ku Ku was nervous.





“Everything ok Ku Ku?” asked his dad flying beside him.

Ku Ku didn’t want to say at first, but Ku Ku’s father is patient.

“We have so far to fly,” said Ku Ku. “I get nervous thinking about it sometimes.”

“It’s normal to feel nervous when you’re doing something new and challenging, Ku Ku” said his dad.

“When I feel nervous, I breathe in very slowly, and breathe out very slowly to help me feel more relaxed.”

Ku Ku's dad took a deep breath in, and let it out slowly.

“How do you usually relax when you feel nervous?” Ku Ku’s father asked.

“I like to sing!” said Ku Ku.





And so Ku Ku's family sang together as they soared across the sky. Soon other families joined in too, and slowly, Ku Ku's wings started to relax again and Ku Ku felt at ease as they continued to fly on this journey to a new and unknown home.

Ku Ku cried out in joy as the mountains opened up to rows of lush green paddy fields in front of them.

The journey was coming to an end and they would be landing to rest for the night soon. Ku Ku felt a sense of calm blow over their wings.

As the sun started to set, they began their descent towards some moving trees next to a rice paddy.





“Looks like the Cranes have made good time,” said Ku Ku's father. Like Ku Ku's community of birds, the cranes, who had lived in the trees next to them, had had to migrate too. They would make their new home here and had offered to let the community of birds Ku Ku was a part of, stay with them to rest before setting off again.

Even though Ku Ku was tired, Ku Ku got to work helping the family build a temporary nest high in the trees. Ku Ku was so tired from having travelled so far in one day, but when Ku Ku laid in the nest that night Ku Ku did not feel like sleeping.

Ku Ku looked up at the stars twinkling in the night sky and shivered, partially because Ku Ku was cold and also because Ku Ku was scared. “Everything ok Ku Ku?” Ku Ku's Auntie asked. “I'm trying to be brave” said Ku Ku “but I'm scared.”

“It can feel scary and confusing when things are changing, Ku Ku” said Auntie Bird. “When I feel scared, I like to imagine a safe place in my mind. Would you like to try this with me?”

Ku Ku nodded and so Auntie bird asked for Ku Ku to close their eyes and imagine a place where Ku Ku felt safe.





“Focus on a time when you felt safe,” said Auntie.

“What can you see, Ku Ku?” asked Auntie bird.

“What can you feel ... and what can you smell in this safe place?” asked Auntie bird.

“Now think about if there is anyone special you would like to invite into your safe place and what you might talk about together ...

You can go to your safe place whenever you feel afraid,” said Auntie bird.

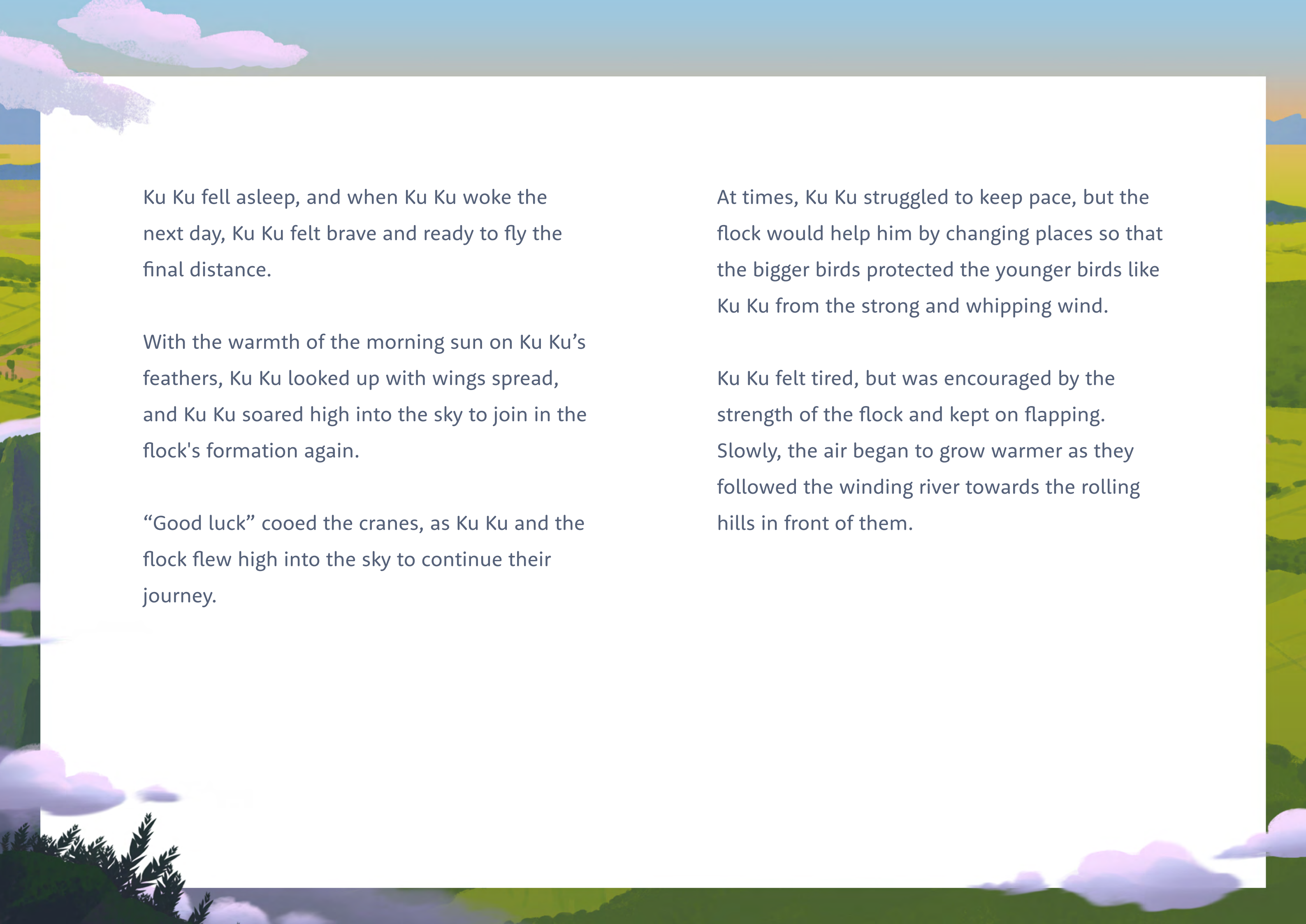
“This is your special power. And remember that I care about you, as does your sister, and all the other birds in this flock too. That will help too.”

“We all care for each other?” said Ku Ku.

“That’s right, Ku Ku,” replied Auntie bird.



OK?



Ku Ku fell asleep, and when Ku Ku woke the next day, Ku Ku felt brave and ready to fly the final distance.

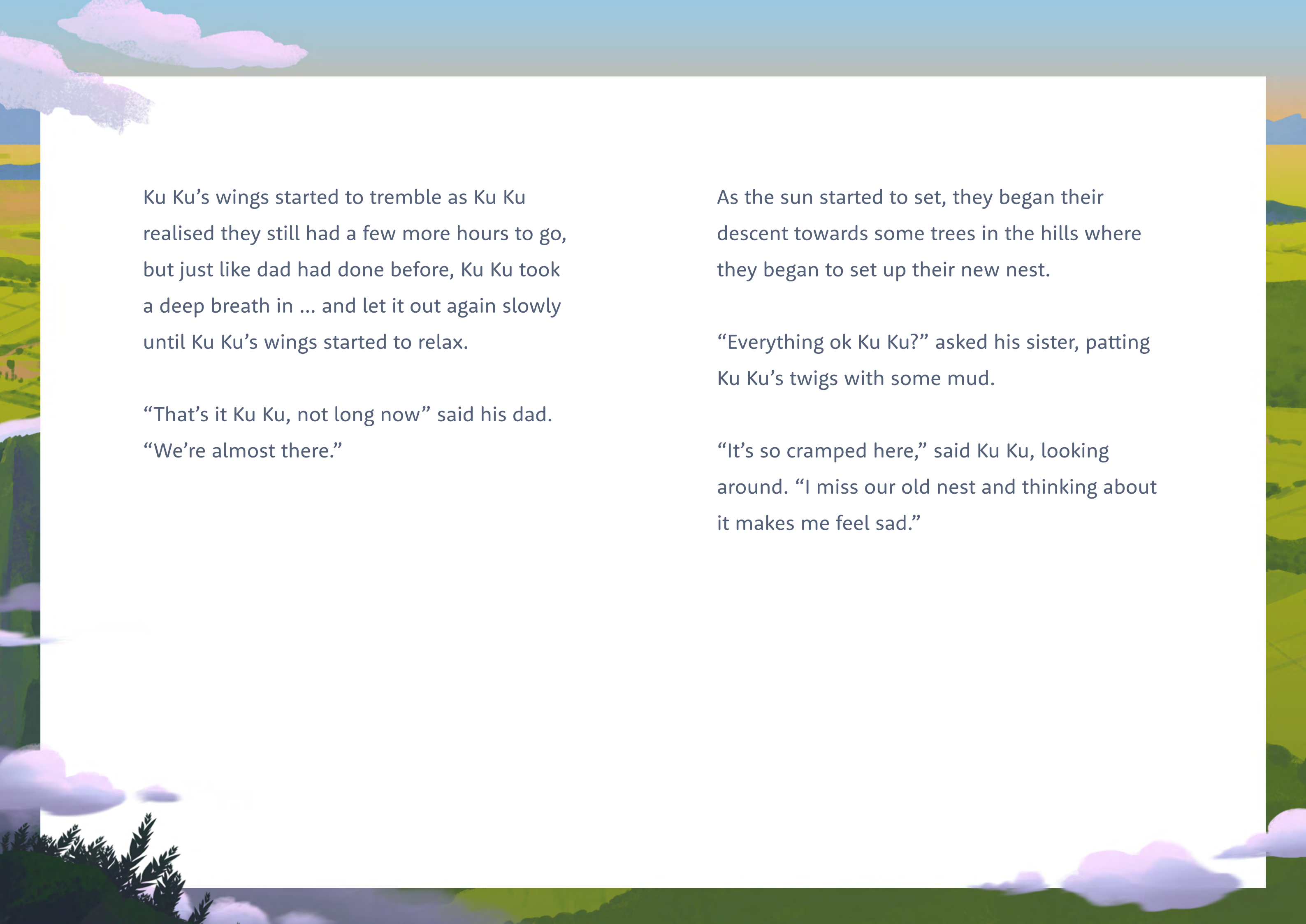
With the warmth of the morning sun on Ku Ku's feathers, Ku Ku looked up with wings spread, and Ku Ku soared high into the sky to join in the flock's formation again.

"Good luck" cooed the cranes, as Ku Ku and the flock flew high into the sky to continue their journey.

At times, Ku Ku struggled to keep pace, but the flock would help him by changing places so that the bigger birds protected the younger birds like Ku Ku from the strong and whipping wind.

Ku Ku felt tired, but was encouraged by the strength of the flock and kept on flapping. Slowly, the air began to grow warmer as they followed the winding river towards the rolling hills in front of them.





Ku Ku's wings started to tremble as Ku Ku realised they still had a few more hours to go, but just like dad had done before, Ku Ku took a deep breath in ... and let it out again slowly until Ku Ku's wings started to relax.

"That's it Ku Ku, not long now" said his dad.

"We're almost there."

As the sun started to set, they began their descent towards some trees in the hills where they began to set up their new nest.

"Everything ok Ku Ku?" asked his sister, patting Ku Ku's twigs with some mud.

"It's so cramped here," said Ku Ku, looking around. "I miss our old nest and thinking about it makes me feel sad."



“It’s normal to feel sad when you leave something behind, Ku Ku” replied sister bird.

“When I’m sad about what I’ve left behind, I like to remember that just because I don’t have that thing anymore, it doesn’t mean it’s not still with me because it will always be in here” she said, placing her wings over Ku Ku’s heart.

Ku Ku closed their eyes and placed their wings over their heart. Ku Ku felt warmth spread to the tips of their feathers as they thought about everything they cared about being with them in Ku Ku’s heart all the time.

“Thanks, big sis. I feel better now” Ku Ku said.

“What else helps to make you feel happy again?” sister asked.

“I like to play loop the loop in the sky with my friends,” Ku Ku said.

“Some things never change,” sister said. And with the warmth of the setting sun on their feathers, Ku Ku and sister looked up, spread their wings, and soared high into the sky to play loop the loop with the other birds.

